

HOW BOLLYWOOD MAKES ITS BIG BUCKS

Multiplexes form 10 per cent of the total screens in India but make 37 per cent of the theatrical revenue because of higher ticket prices

65% of the box office collections come from non-metros
30% revenue is likely to come from home videos by 2020
13% of TV revenue is from film content
480 is the total number of multiplexes in India till now

All-time Top 10 Indian movies in UK and US

1. *Bride and Prejudice*, Aishwarya Rai's bid for world domination, directed by Gurinder Chadha, earned Rs 87.60 crore
2. *Monsoon Wedding*, directed by Mira Nair, made Rs 79.55 crore
3. *The Namesake*, directed by Mira Nair, grossed Rs 62.82 crore
4. *Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham*, a sort of karva chauth-meets-Cavalli, directed by Karan Johar, made Rs 31.49 crore
5. *Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna*, a haute couture version of adultery, directed by Karan Johar, earned Rs 29.75 crore
6. *Veer-Zaara*, directed by Yash Chopra, netted Rs 28.99 crore
7. *Devdas*, directed by Sanjay Bhansali, made Rs 25.30 crore
8. *Kal Ho Na Ho*, directed by Nikhil Advani, made Rs 22.11 crore
9. *Don: The Chase Begins Again*, Shah Rukh Khan's bid to be Bachchan, directed by Farhan Akhtar, earned Rs 21.43 crore
10. *Dhoom 2*, directed by Sanjay Gadhvi, netted Rs 12 crore

highly undercapitalised industry which pales in comparison with its smaller but richer competitor, television. It's an industry which deals with fractions of the sum that Hollywood handles. It's an industry where technology is changing but with the speed of paint peeling off a wall. And it's an industry where every altered state begets an unalterable reality. So even as Indians learn to download film ringtones on their mobiles (up to 8,00,000 a day), they don't know how to—or don't care to—access movie content on the Internet (penetration in India is 5 per cent compared to 21 per cent in

Brazil and 70 per cent in the US). Even as Indians put the most number of bottoms on theatre seats in the world, they spend hugely less (an average film ticket in India costs \$0.5 compared to \$6 in the US). Even as we celebrate our Karan Johars and Shah Rukh Khans as the emperors of the overseas market, it is two Punjabi *kudis*, separated only by the Atlantic Ocean, Gurinder Chadha and Mira Nair, who have cornered the top slots on the box office charts in the US and the UK. Despite the rising number of analog prints for Bollywood movies, we live with not being able to get prints to small towns faster than

two-eight weeks because of high costs (each additional print costs Rs 60,000).

The report reiterates some obvious truths. Yes, we suspected that more than half the audiences in theatres are between 15 and 34 (Bollywood could not be so off-the-mark in its obsession with youth. We also assumed that piracy was rampant (it is, especially in small towns, where 42 per cent of those who watch movies at home do so thanks to pirated DVDs). Besides, India has one of the lowest densities of theatres (12 screens per one million population, compared to 117 in the US, 77 for France and 52 in Italy).

What does the report say about where Bollywood is at, with its spiraling star salaries, ubiquity in the public eye and big bucks backroom deals? Simple. It's got a long way to go babe. In the words of Cecelia Brady, the daughter of a Hollywood mogul in *The Last Tycoon*, "not half a dozen men have ever been able to keep the whole equation of pictures in their heads". It was true of the Old Hollywood and it is true even now. The professionals are a handful, who are in the business not just because they want to make a fast million with instant fame thrown in. The rest are carpetbaggers and charlatans whose mouths work faster than their minds.

Because it needs more than just a sprinkling of stars and a trend *du jour* to make Bollywood bigger. It needs to respect the ensemble of talent that goes into the making of movies, the craftsmen who make the props emote and the writers who can make even the cliché click. Television is already feeling the heat, with the mass in mass media asserting itself. And the music industry felt it long ago, shrinking in size from Rs 1,000 crore in 2000 to Rs 650 crore last year because of digitisation.

In Hollywood, the six big studios which have a 96 per cent market share of the box office collections, get 98 per cent of the national prime-time television advertising dollars, and have 80 per cent of the subscribers to pay-television services, are under threat from the digital download. Thanks to low Internet penetration, Bollywood has no such fear right now. But as YouTube has shown the world, a revolution is just a click away. ■